Let's Get Practical: Building a Prayer Life

'Lord, teach us to pray'
The 'prayer of Jesus' disciples in Luke 11:1

Jesus' Pattern for Prayer:

Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name,

your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.

Give us today our daily bread.

And forgive us our debts,
as we also have forgiven our debtors.

And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from the evil one.

For yours is the Kingdom
the power and the glory,
Forever and ever, Amen.

Other Simple Patterns of Prayer

A Adoration
C Confession
T Thanksgiving
S Supplication

Or

T Thank you
S Sorry
P Please



Tips for building a Prayer Life

- 'When you pray, go into your room, close the door and pray to your Father, who is unseen. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you. ' (Matt 6:6) Find a quiet and comfortable spot, free from distractions, and give time to God. If you have a mind that drifts easily to the tasks of the day, why not have a note pad on which you can quickly make a note to follow up later and then focus your attention back on God?

- Keep it simple (v. 7) and don't worry about having a whizz-bang prayer life straight away—it is better to be short, artless and sincere, than waffly, eloquent and fake. 'Keep it simple, keep it real, keep it up.'

- Build a time for prayer into your daily routine/ rhythms. e.g. I have a 'kettle prayer' for whenever I make a cup of tea! Don't try to conquer Rome in a day: its better to start with 5 minutes a day than aim for something unrealistic and unsustainable.

'Pray as you can, not as you can't'
Dom Chapman

- Horses for courses: Some people find it helpful to light a candle, or kneel, or play some music in the background, so that they can 'marinate in God's presence like a pickle'! Others like to pray whilst doing something practical (e.g. gardening, peeling spuds etc.) or getting out in nature (walking the dog, going for a run etc.). If you're creative perhaps painting, making, playing or composing something for God might help get the juices flowing. Some people find keeping a 'prayer journal' really works, writing prayers for themselves or others, that way you can then look back over time to see how God has answered prayer. Whatever you do, **pray out of who you are, not out of who you're not**.

- Silence is your friend.

- If you're an extrovert and find private prayer difficult, why not get a prayer buddy or prayer triplet to pray with regularly?

- Sometimes prayer will be hard work, will feel fuzzy or against the grain—this is natural; like any relationship there are times when prayer will zing along, and others when it won't. Stick with it—God hearing your prayer is not dependent on whether you're 'feeling it' or not. Sometimes the most formative prayer experiences are those when God feels most absent, 'cause then you're doing the real spadework of faith.

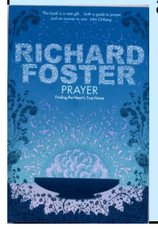
- Your prayer life/habits will change over time—this is a good sign.

- **Just go for it!** Don't be worried about making a fool of yourself.

Suggestions for Further Reading:



Stephen Cottrell, *How to Pray: Alone, with others , at any time, in any place* (Church House, 2010) - A 'basic primer on prayer', simple and straight forward.



Richard Foster, *Prayer: Finding the Heart's True Home,* (Hodder, 2008) - An in-depth and more comprehensive exploration of the many variations of prayer. Good for dipping into further down the line perhaps.

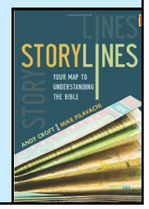
Let's Get Practical: Handling the Word

Here are two links to 3 minute videos which give an overview of the Bible:
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wC32RCqLok4
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JiJXdfX9YoI



<u>Suggestions for Further Reading:</u>

Andy Croft and Mike Pilavachi, *Storylines: Your Map to Understanding the Bible* (David C. Cook, 2010)



Some tips for reading the Bible:

- **When?** Establish a daily rhythm of reading—e.g. first thing or just after lunch or before bed—whenever you're likely to be 'in the zone' and free from distractions. Find a quiet spot (TV off, door shut, phone on silent etc.) and ask God to speak to you through the passage. Then read it slowly through a couple of times. Perhaps have a notebook to hand to scribble down anything that stands out, and then spend some time talking to God about what you've read and what it might mean for your life.

- Either **DIY:** Why not read a chapter a day? If you're wondering where to start—one or more of the Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke and John) might be a good first port of call. The book of Acts, the letter of Philippians, the collection of wise sayings in Proverbs, or the song book called Psalms are also good doorways into the Bible I think. I remember enjoying getting stuck into Genesis and 1 Samuel too as a Bible newby.

- Or **get some study aids**: You can get daily Bible reading or devotional books/booklets from a Christian bookstore or online which suggest a passage to read and then include a short reflection on it. A google search would show you there are lots of online alternatives of this if you're that way inclined. A good example of one of these, (which also happens to be free) is: http://www.wordlive.org
  These hip'n'groovy days you can also get them in the form of phone apps:
  See e.g. http://www.thegoodbook.co.uk/explore-app

- You can also get hold of 'study Bibles' which have notes at the bottom of the page to explain words or references which might be bamboozling you or to suggest how the passage is relevant to everyday life. The NIV study Bible or Life Application Bible are particularly popular versions. They also contain lots of maps, charts, illustrations and other bits and bobs to help explain the background.

- One of the best ways to get to grips with the Bible is of course to look at it with others. Hence the discipleship habit of attending home groups, sermons, one-to-ones etc.

- If you're up for reading the whole thing, there are Bible reading schemes which suggest daily readings etc. Some people aim to go cover to cover in a year which would probably mean reading 3 or 4 chapters a day.